

re-entered the atmosphere and landed in Kazakhstan, about 1 hour and 48 minutes after launch.

The Vostok spacecraft was designed to eject the cosmonaut at approximately 7 km and allow him to return to earth by parachute. Although initial reports made it unclear whether Gagarin landed in this manner or returned in the spacecraft, subsequent reports confirmed that he did indeed eject from the capsule. Radio communications with earth were continuous during the flight, and television transmissions were also made from space.

Gagarin instantly became an international hero and is often referred to as the 'Columbus of the Cosmos'. For the next few years, he became the posterboy for Russia's seeming dominance over the US and he was paraded around the globe. When Gagarin finally returned to Russia and started training for a second mission, an air crash ended his life on March 27, 1968.

To commemorate the 50th anniversary of Gagarin's historic spaceflight, filmmaker Christopher Riley and the European Space Agency released a short film in 2011 titled *First Orbit*, which replicates what Gagarin must have seen in his first flight and complements it with archival audio footage. It can be seen online at www.firstflight.org.

Gagarin was soon followed into space by his colleague Gherman Titov, who went aboard the Vostok II on August 6, 1961, for the first full-day manned mission in space. Over the next few years, the Soviets would launch four more manned missions into space, including Valentina Tereshkova, who would become the first woman in space on June 19, 1963.



Cosmonaut Yuri Gagarin preparing to become the first man in space

Project Mercury

Let's rewind the clock a little. In 1958, two months after NASA was formed, its administrator Dr. T. Keith Glennan announced that the organisation would be looking to send a man into space as well. Obviously, the Soviets won this fight, but to understand the future missions NASA undertook, it's important to know about this programme, which would be called 'Project Mercury'.